

Session 11: Spiritual Gifts and the Body of Christ

Key Takeaways

- The Spirit gives spiritual gifts to people and works those gifts within and through them.
- Paul denounces the idea that tongues is the “best” gift by teaching that the Spirit works equally through all the gifts—no gift receives a lesser working from the Spirit.
- Paul uses the metaphor of a body to describe the nature and function of Jesus’ Church. While a body is a single, unified whole, it consists of different parts working uniquely toward a common goal.
- In his body, Jesus brings together a variety of gifts, and the Spirit unifies them all.

Spiritual Gifts

Chapters 12 and 13 should be read together, but often chapter 13 is taken out of context as a superlative passage on the nature of love.

Paul begins the section with “Concerning spiritual gifts” This signals for us that he’s talking about something they’ve talked about first or maybe in response to his first letter.

Anathema Jesus

He begins with a reference to idols and then makes this point about Jesus.

1 Corinthians 12:3 Instructor’s Translation

No one can say ‘Anathema Jesus’ (Greek: *anathema Iesous* / Ἀνάθεμα Ἰησοῦς—Jesus [is] cursed) if they are speaking in the Spirit. No one can say Jesus [is] Lord except by the Spirit.

We’re unsure of what Paul is referring to here. Are they saying that Jesus is cursed or are they cursing others in the “name of Jesus”? Dr. Peppiatt’s opinion is that the latter makes more sense because then he turns to spiritual gifts, so it appears that what he’s addressing is what it looks like to function “in the Spirit.”

Work of the Spirit

Here Paul uses the word *διαίρεσεις* (Greek: *diaireseis*—varieties plural) three times in relation to gifts, service/ministries, and “workings.”

The Spirit gives a variety of different things, but it is the same Spirit who “works” them all.

The criteria for knowing whether it is the Spirit at work or not is the proclamation that Jesus is Lord.

ἐνεργημάτων means “many workings” (Greek: *energmaton*—operations). The one God or same God is working them all in everyone, but later we’ll see that Paul references the same Lord and the same Spirit. God the Spirit

does this for the common good.

In Trinitarian theology, we have a maxim called the “principle of inseparable operations.” This means that the actions of one member of the Trinity are the actions of all three members—the Son’s actions are not separate from the actions of the Father or the Spirit. This unity exists while the three persons of the Trinity remain distinct.

What Are All These Gifts?

1 Corinthians 12:8-11 NIV

⁸ To one there is given through the Spirit a message of wisdom, to another a message of knowledge by means of the same Spirit, ⁹ to another faith by the same Spirit, to another gifts of healing by that one Spirit, ¹⁰ to another miraculous powers, to another prophecy, to another distinguishing between spirits, to another speaking in different kinds of tongues, and to still another the interpretation of tongues. ¹¹ All these are the work of one and the same Spirit, and he distributes them to each one, just as he determines.

In verse 12 Paul says, “in this way also Christ.” He brings together in his body a diversity of things, and the Spirit is the unifying feature between us all.

The Body Metaphor

In 1 Corinthians 10:2-4, Paul mentions the Israelites being baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea and drinking from the spiritual rock that is Christ. 1 Corinthians 12:13 says we’re all baptized into one body by the Spirit, and given one Spirit to drink. This is very similar to Galatians 3:26-28, which also mentions baptism and the equality of Jew and Gentile and slave and free. Here we don’t read male and female.

What is the significance of the body parts he chooses?

- The seemingly weaker members are indispensable (1 Cor. 12:22).
- The dishonorable parts are those that we treat with special honor (1 Cor. 12:23).
- Parts that are unpresentable are treated with special modesty.

There is a priority of gifts (1 Cor. 12:27-30). The greater gifts are apostles, prophets, teachers, in that order. Yet Paul connects this to the larger theme of unity as he transitions to the next chapter.

1 Corinthians 12:31 NIV

Now eagerly desire the greater gifts. And yet I will show you the most excellent way.

Reflection Question

What have you already heard or learned about spiritual gifts before starting this course? How do those things align or misalign with what Paul is teaching the Corinthians in this passage?

The Greatest of These Is Love

Key Takeaways

- 1 Corinthians 13 is the centerpiece of Paul's teaching on the gifts of the Spirit in chapters 12 through 14.
- Paul emphasizes the gifts of prophecy, knowledge, and tongues because various groups were mistakenly valuing some of these gifts over others.
- Rather than making disconnected judgments from the sidelines, Paul writes in the first person, humbly including himself with the Corinthians as a participating member of their group who both celebrates and suffers with them.

The Centrality of Love

Paul begins chapter 13 by switching into the first person. What does it do to us as hearers and readers that Paul uses the first person here? Paul does not stand at a distance from the truth he shares with the Corinthians because he, too, would be nothing without love.

Note which gifts Paul mentions in 1 Corinthians 13:1-3. This chapter is not a side topic; it is central to his teaching on the issues the Corinthian church is struggling with—speaking in tongues, prophecy, and knowledge.

What Love Is

In 1 Corinthians 13:4, Paul begins to express what love is with two affirmations of what love does do. He talks about love *μακροθυμεῖ* (Greek: *makrothymeō*—to persevere, be patient, long-suffering, forbearing), and love *χρηστεύεται* (Greek: *chresteuomai*—to be kind, gentle).

What Love Is Not

Apophatic theology describes the nature of God by expressing what he is not. Paul takes this approach, describing what love does not do.

1 Corinthians 13:4b-6 NIV*

^{4b} It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud (Greek: *phusioō* / *φυσιόω*—puffed up, arrogant). ⁵ It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs. ⁶ Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Paul uses *φυσιόω* a number of times in the letter to describe the Corinthians.

All Things

In 13:7, Paul repeats “all things” four times.

- Love covers/endures (Greek: *panta stegai* / πάντα στέγει)
- Love believes/trusts (Greek: *panta pisteuei* / πάντα πιστεύει)
- Hopes (Greek: *panta elpizei* / πάντα ἐλπίζει)
- Endures, remains, waits upon (Greek: *panta hypomenei* / πάντα ὑπομένει)

Love Endures

Paul concludes the description of love in 1 Corinthians 13:8, stating that “love never fails/falls (Greek: *piptei* / πίπτει).” He then contrasts the enduring nature of love with the temporary nature of the spiritual gifts he started the chapter with—prophecy, tongues, and knowledge. Ultimately, all that is only partial will be abolished to give way to that which is perfect and complete (1 Cor. 13:10).

They all cease (Greek: *katargeo* / καταργέω—to render inoperative, abolish) in order to give way to a new order. Tongues will cease and will give way to our heavenly worship. Prophecies will no longer be needed as we have a full revelation of the divine nature. Completeness, wholeness, and fullness will come.

1 Corinthians 13:11 NIV*

When I was a child, I talked like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child. When I became a man, I nullified (Greek: *katergeka* / κατήργηκα) the ways of childhood.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Now and Then

Note the pairs of contrast between what we experience “now” and what we look forward to “then.”

1 Corinthians 13:12-13 NIV

¹² For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known. ¹³ And now these three remain: faith, hope and love. But the greatest of these is love.

The reflection is seen “dimly” (Greek: *ainigmati* / αἰνίγματι—linked to enigma).

When we get to 1 Corinthians 15, we’ll see that some things endure (the body) and some things are abolished.

Reflection Question

Paul designed 1 Corinthians 12 and 13 to be read and understood together. How does chapter 12 help us understand chapter 13?